as the predominantly Meitei population in the Imphal Valley and the Kukis who dominate the hills grew barbed wire in their minds. In bone-dry statistics, about 200 killed, 1,000 injured and 60,000 homeless between May and August. All this while the state police and even the armed forces, for the most part, remained helpless spectators. Even arms and ammunition were looted from the police constabulary amid allegations of state complicity.

Such an absolute, prolonged collapse of the law and order in any state—at any time in modern Indian history—would have brought down a swift guillotine on the prevailing setup. Either in the form of President's Rule or via a change of guard. But Singh's incumbency not only endured, paradoxically it perhaps emerged stronger, with his castle gates now made of iron. Rather than damaging him, the charge that a Meitei CM had acted as an unabashed partisan—to the point where the Kukis even started talking of the need for a separate administration—gave him endless immunity. He had instituted himself in Meitei folklore as a hero who stood his ground for their cause. In Manipur, where 40 of the 60 assembly constituencies are in the Meitei-dominated Imphal Valley, the criticism was a blessing in disguise for Singh. It became difficult for his bosses up the BJP pyramid to touch him, especially because the ethnic conflict had taken on unambiguously communal colours. Better, then, to sup with him.

THE CRISIS

- Biren presided over an astonishingly complete, and prolonged, collapse of law and order during the Meitei-Kuki violence
- His open pro-Meitei stance made it difficult for the BJP high command to remove him from office
- A video of Kuki women being assaulted caused nationwide horror

For nearly eight months the state has remained geographically divided along ethnic lines with no reconciliation in sight



NATIONAL SHAME
A screen grab showing two Kuki women being paraded naked by a mob

The former BSF constable—who did duty as right fullback on the football field back in the early '80s—has had to do some hectic defending ever since he took office in 2017. Facing dissent almost every six months, Singh had to be at New Delhi's mercy for survival. His none-too-subtle side-taking this time, while notching zero points in terms of his constitutional duty, ended that phase of vulnerability—a choreographed show of his new might, with a resignation drama lobbed in, proved that in June.

Meitei-Kuki tensions are not a new development. But as Singh initiated a crackdown on drug trafficking and poppy cultivation, Kuki suspicions about his intent rose because a majority of poppy fields were in areas inhabited by them, often encroaching upon unclassed forests. This despite the fact that more Meitei families—143 against 59 Kukis—were evicted in the drive. His unilateral withdrawal of a suspension of operation agreement with two Kuki militant groups due to their alleged role in instigating people against the eviction widened the divide. So did his conflation of militancy and the drug menace with "illegal" refugees of the extended Kuki-Chin-Zomi-Mizo ethnicity from conflict-torn Myanmar: 2,500 officially, but thought to be higher. Here, he both reflected and fed into Meitei anxieties, while fuelling insecurity among Kukis. But the actual trigger was not pulled by him. This came via an April 19 order of the Manipur High Court suggesting the inclusion of Meiteis in the ST list: a protest rally on May 3 saw the sparks set off a forest fire of hatred. The irony is, it could well have been otherwise, with the man at the centre of it gaining a positive aura. His 'Go To Hills' drive, which now lies in a shambles, was a model policy built around ethnic equity and amity. ■